T OPENING UP

A CLUTCH OF NEW AGREEMENTS SIGNAL INDIA'S BOLD BUT RISKY GAMBIT TO JOIN THE BIG LEAGUE OF TRADING NATIONS

By **RAJ CHENGAPPA**

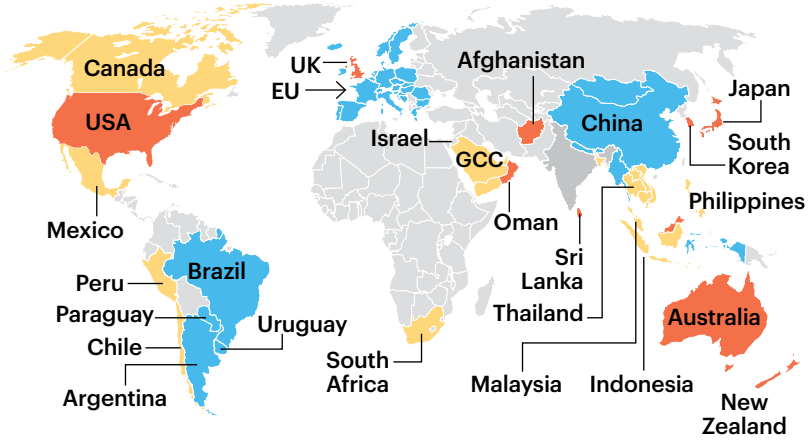
Photo illustration by **BANDEEP SINGH/ AI**

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi picked up the phone to speak to US president Donald Trump on the evening of February 2, it was arguably the biggest foreign and economic policy call he would make. It marked the final act of a carefully choreographed tightrope walk to pull off an economic coup akin to what Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao and his finance minister Dr Manmohan Singh achieved in 1991 when they ushered in transformative economic reforms. In the preceding months, Modi had painstakingly worked to build momentum for what could be India's greatest international trade outreach since Independence.

It would culminate in India signing trade deals with a host of nations whose combined GDP stands at $60 trillion (Rs 5,440 lakh crore)—roughly half of the global GDP. These mega deals signal the crystallisation of a new trade doctrine: that India is no longer hedging between openness and protectionism; that it is consciously preparing to compete with, and alongside, the world's most demanding economies; and that, after decades in which a large domestic market allowed Indian industry to remain inward-looking and comfortable, there is a pressing need, as one expert put it, to rewire India's growth model to place manufacturing, exports, and global integration at its core.

INDIA'S BIG PUSH

From signed deals to active negotiations, India expands economic partnerships across continents



INDIA'S TRADE AGREEMENTS

Multilateral Bilateral Bilateral under negotiation

IT'S RAINING DEALS

India has concluded nine free trade agreements over the past five years



CONCLUDED AGREEMENTS

- USA *2026*
- EU *2026*
- FTA (New Zealand) *2025*
- CEPA (Oman) *2025*
- CETA (UK) *2025*
- TEPA (EFTA*) *2024*
- ECTA (Australia) *2022*
- CEPA (UAE) *2022*
- CECPA (Mauritius) *2021*

**Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, & Liechtenstein*

ACTIVE NEGOTIATIONS

- Mexico
- Canada
- Israel
- GCC**
- Qatar
- Peru & Chile
- ASEAN#

***Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE*

#Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, Vietnam and Timor-Leste



Sources: Ministry of Commerce and Industry, PIB

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